



VANTAGE POINTS: Students practising the ancient martial art form of Kalaripayattu at a beach in Kozhikode, Kerala (above); the Jantar Mantar observatory in Jaipur (below left); Haji Ali on Eid day in Mumbai



years now, does this by rigging a camera to a custom-made kite. The 170-odd photographs in the sumptuous book create a new perspective of India, where the monumental and the commonplace engage in a relationship of pure geometry and form.

In an aerial perspective, one transcends hierarchies of familiarity and proximity in one's relationship with people and things. Everything is reduced to a flat architectural shape equidistant from the eye that peers down vertically. This creates a strange objectivity for familiar settings and

emotions. Looked at from above, the people we classify on the basis of caste, race and religion turn into uniform black dots; buildings become geometric shapes—imagine the dome of the Taj Mahal as an upturned coffee cup.

The difference between conventional aerial photography from a chopper and from a camera rigged on to a large kite is that with the latter, one can shoot unobtrusively at far lower altitudes. This helps create images with a palpable sense of height and scale, as though one were just hovering above the structure. The photograph of the

lighthouse at Mahabalipuram or the clocktower in Lucknow causes a sensation similar to the numbing zing you feel at the peak of a merry-go-round.

The real rewards of the book are its photographs of new architectural facets of some of the most well-known monuments of India. There are panoramic photographs of the entire lengths of the Amber and Mehrangarh forts in Rajasthan, contrasting their looming structures with the chaotic townships around them. The temple shikhars of Khajuraho and Hampi have been photographed with such geometric precision that they might as well be architectural blueprints.

By rigging the camera to a symbol of free spirit, the photographer has elevated our perceptual experience of the most commonly viewed sights of our country. Yet, Chorier's vision is at best that of the tourist following the Lonely Planet guidebook. The real experience of India is far more layered. But that is something for the next book. This time the kite took the eyes, it now needs to take the heart. ■